ORAL ENGLISH · ORAL FORMS

VOWEL SOUNDS

Monophthongs · Diphthongs · Triphthongs | JAMB · WAEC · NECO

PrepNAce
REVISION CHEATSHEET

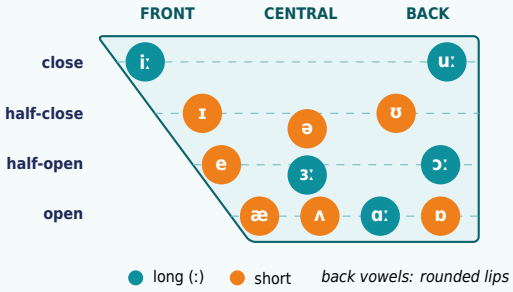
iː ɪ e æ ɜː ə ʌ uː ʊ ɔː ɒ ɑː eɪ aɪ ɔɪ əʊ aʊ ɪə eə ʊə

★ 1 · THE BASICS

- **Vowel** = voiced sound made with *free airflow* (nothing blocks the air).
- Letters ≠ sounds: **5 vowel letters** (a, e, i, o, u) but **20 vowel sounds**.
- **Monophthong** (pure vowel): one steady sound, e.g. **/iː/** in *see*.
- **Diphthong**: glide between two vowels in *one* syllable, e.g. **/aɪ/** in *time*.
- **Length mark /ː/** = long vowel. One vowel sound = one syllable.

7 short + 5 long = 12 pure vowels
3 + 2 + 3 = 8 diphthongs
12 + 8 = 20 vowel sounds

◉ 2 · THE VOWEL CHART (tongue position)



♪ 3 · THE 12 PURE VOWELS (MONOPHTHONGS)

Sound	Length	Tongue	Height	Lips	Key words (red = spelling of the sound)
/iː/	long	front	close	spread	**see** • **sea** • **k**e**y** • **fie**ld • **peo**ple • rec**ei**ve
/ɪ/	short	front	half-close	spread	s**i**t • b**u**sy • w**o**men • v**i**llage • m**y**th
/e/	short	front	half-open	spread	b**e**d • h**ea**d • s**ai**d • m**a**ny • fr**ie**nd
/æ/	short	front	open	spread	c**a**t • m**a**n • bl**a**ck • h**a**nd • h**a**ppy
/ɜː/	long	central	half-open	neutral	b**ir**d • h**er** • w**or**k • l**ear**n • t**ur**n • j**our**ney
/ə/	short	central	half-open	neutral	**a**bout • teach**er** • sof**a** • doct**or** • banan**a**
/ʌ/	short	central	open	neutral	c**u**p • l**o**ve • s**o**n • bl**oo**d • c**ou**ntry
/uː/	long	back	close	rounded	f**oo**d • bl**ue** • sh**oe** • thr**ough** • fr**ui**t • m**o**ve
/ʊ/	short	back	half-close	rounded	p**u**t • b**oo**k • c**ou**ld • w**o**man • f**oo**t
/ɔː/	long	back	half-open	rounded	d**oor** • s**aw** • b**or**n • c**augh**t • f**our** • w**a**ter
/ɒ/	short	back	open	rounded	h**o**t • c**ou**gh • w**a**tch • w**a**nt • d**o**g
/ɑː/	long	back	open	neutral	c**a**r • f**a**rm • c**a**lm • h**ea**rt • h**a**lf • f**a**ther

★ **/ə/** (schwa): commonest vowel, only in *weak* syllables. ★ **Silent r** unless a vowel follows: *car* /kɑː/, *carry* /ˈkæri/.

⚡ 4 · THE 8 DIPHTHONGS (glides)

Sound	Glides to	Key words
/eɪ/	/ɪ/ closing	d**ay** • r**ai**n • **eigh**t • gr**ea**t • th**ey**
/aɪ/	/ɪ/ closing	m**y** • h**igh** • b**uy** • t**i**me • f**i**ve
/ɔɪ/	/ɪ/ closing	b**oy** • **oi**l • c**oi**n • enj**oy**
/əʊ/	/ʊ/ closing	g**o** • b**oa**t • kn**ow** • n**o**se • s**ou**l
/aʊ/	/ʊ/ closing	n**ow** • h**ou**se • c**ow** • **ou**t • cl**ou**d
/ɪə/	/ə/ centring	h**ere** • b**eer** • **ear** • id**ea** • n**ear**
/eə/	/ə/ centring	**air** • c**are** • b**ear** • th**ere** • p**air**
/ʊə/	/ə/ centring	t**our** • p**oor** • p**ure** • s**ure** • c**ure**

Triphthongs = diphthong + /ə/: **/aɪə/** f**ire** • **/aʊə/** h**our** • **/eɪə/** pl**ay**er

✓ 5 · SAME SPELLING, DIFFERENT SOUNDS

Letters	Sounds they can make
a	c**a**t /æ/ • f**a**ther /ɑː/ • c**a**ke /eɪ/ • **a**bout /ə/
e	b**e**d /e/ • m**e** /iː/ • h**er** /ɜː/
i	s**i**t /ɪ/ • t**i**me /aɪ/ • b**ir**d /ɜː/ • mach**i**ne /iː/
o	h**o**t /ɒ/ • g**o** /əʊ/ • l**o**ve /ʌ/ • d**o** /uː/ • w**or**k /ɜː/
u	c**u**p /ʌ/ • p**u**t /ʊ/ • r**u**le /uː/ • t**u**rn /ɜː/
ea	**ea**t /iː/ • br**ea**d /e/ • gr**ea**t /eɪ/ • h**ea**rt /ɑː/ • l**ea**rn /ɜː/
ou	h**ou**se /aʊ/ • s**ou**p /uː/ • c**ou**ld /ʊ/ • c**ou**ntry /ʌ/ • f**our** /ɔː/
oo	f**oo**d /uː/ • b**oo**k /ʊ/ • bl**oo**d /ʌ/ • d**oor** /ɔː/

♪ 6 · MINIMAL PAIRS (only the vowel changes)

Contrast	Word pairs
/iː/–/ɪ/	sheep–ship • seat–sit • leave–live
/e/–/æ/	pen–pan • men–man • bed–bad
/æ/–/ʌ/	cat–cut • ran–run • bag–bug
/ʌ/–/ɑː/	cut–cart • luck–lark • bun–barn
/ɒ/–/ɔː/	cot–caught • pot–port • shot–short
/ʊ/–/uː/	full–fool • pull–pool • look–Luke
/ɒ/–/əʊ/	not–note • cot–coat • rod–road
/e/–/eɪ/	pen–pain • met–mate • test–taste
/ɜː/–/ɔː/	bird–board • shirt–short • firm–form

⚠ 7 · WATCH OUT: COMMON MISTAKES

- **/ɪ/** and **/iː/** merged: *sit* = *seat*. Keep **/ɪ/** short, **/iː/** long.
- **/ʊ/** and **/uː/** merged: *full* = *fool*.
- **/ɒ/** and **/ɔː/** merged: *cot* = *caught*.
- **/æ/** said as /a/ or /e/: *man*, *bad*, *cat*.
- **/ʌ/** said as /ɔ/ or /a/: *cup*, *love*, *son*.
- **/ɜː/** said as /ɛ/ or /ɔ/: *bird*, *work*, *turn*.
- Diphthongs shortened: **/eɪ/**→/e/ (*day*), **/əʊ/**→/o/ (*go*).
- **/ə/** replaced by the spelling vowel: *doctor*, *banana*.
- **Fix:** trust your *ears*, not the spelling. Practise minimal pairs aloud.

✎ 8 · WORKED EXAMPLES

Q1. Same vowel sound as heart? (A) heat (B) hurt (C) hard (D) head
Solution: heart **/hɑːt/** → **/ɑː/**. heat **/iː/**, hurt **/ɜː/**, hard **/ɑː/**, head **/e/**.
Answer: C.

Q2. Odd one out: (A) boat (B) go (C) cow (D) note
Solution: boat /əʊ/, go /əʊ/, cow /aʊ/, note /əʊ/. **Answer: C**.

★ 9 · EXAM STRATEGY

1. **Ignore spelling.** Say each word aloud and listen to the vowel.
2. **Write the IPA** in your head; compare *symbols*, not letters.
3. **Long or short?** Only **/iː ɑː ɔː uː ɜː/** are long.
4. **Diphthong endings:** *day, my, boy* → **/ɪ/**; *go, now* → **/ʊ/**; *here, air, tour* → **/ə/**.
5. **Rhymes** share the vowel + ending: *heart–part* **/ɑːt/**.